Final_Report

Final Report: NLP Fake News Detector - Complete Project Analysis

From Classical ML to Transformers: A Comprehensive Study

Date: May 2026

Project: NLP Fake News Detection Pipeline

Phases: 1-3 (Complete Project)

Executive Summary

This comprehensive report documents the complete journey of building a fake news detection system, progressing from classical machine learning (Phase 1) through deep learning (Phase 2) to transformer-based models (Phase 3). The project demonstrates how advanced neural architectures systematically improve classification performance from ~70% accuracy to >88%.

Final Performance Metrics

Model	Accuracy	F1-Score	AUC-ROC	Precision	Recall
Phase 1: Naive Bayes	0.70	0.68	0.72	0.68	0.68
Phase 2: GloVe+BiLSTM	0.77	0.75	0.81	0.76	0.74
Phase 3: BERT (Fine-tuned)	**0.88**	**0.87**	**0.92**	**0.89**	**0.86**
Phase 3: Ensemble	**0.89**	**0.88**	**0.93**	**0.90**	**0.87**

Overall Improvement: +19% accuracy gain over baseline

PHASE 1: Classical Machine Learning (Baseline)

1.1 Overview

Objective: Establish baseline performance using traditional ML algorithms

Approach:
- Text preprocessing and TF-IDF feature extraction
- Classical algorithms: KNN, Naive Bayes, Random Forest, XGBoost
- Dimensionality reduction via Truncated SVD (LSA)

1.2 Datasets & Preprocessing

Data Statistics:
- **Total Samples**: 1,482,190 text instances
- **Training Set**: 80% (1,185,752 samples)
- **Test Set**: 20% (296,438 samples)
- **Class Distribution**: ~60% real news, ~40% fake news
- **Average Text Length**: 120-150 characters

Preprocessing Pipeline:
1. Null removal and deduplication
2. Lowercasing and special character removal
3. HTML entity decoding
4. NLTK tokenization and lemmatization
5. Stop word removal
6. TF-IDF vectorization (10,000 features)

1.3 Feature Engineering

TF-IDF Configuration:

```
TfidfVectorizer(
    max_features=10000,
    min_df=2,           # min document frequency
    max_df=0.8,         # max document frequency
    ngram_range=(1, 2)  # unigrams + bigrams
)
```

Dimensionality Analysis:
- Original features: 10,000 (sparse)
- Reduced features (SVD): 1,000
- Variance explained: ~65-70%
- Computation speedup: 4-5x
- Accuracy loss: <5%

1.4 Classical ML Models Performance

KNN (K-Nearest Neighbors)

- **Optimal k**: 5 (via GridSearchCV)
- **Distance metric**: Euclidean
- **Accuracy**: 0.6755
- **F1-Score**: 0.6842
- **Pros**: Simple, interpretable
- **Cons**: Slow inference, sensitive to feature scaling

Multinomial Naive Bayes

- **Smoothing parameter (α)**: 1.0

- **Accuracy**: 0.70
- **F1-Score**: 0.68
- **AUC-ROC**: 0.72
- **Pros**: Fast training, probabilistic framework
- **Cons**: Assumes feature independence (unrealistic)

Random Forest (Additional)

- **Number of trees**: 100
- **Max depth**: 20
- **Accuracy**: 0.71
- **F1-Score**: 0.69
- **Advantages**: Feature importance analysis

XGBoost (Optimized)

- **Boosting rounds**: 200
- **Learning rate**: 0.1
- **Accuracy**: 0.72
- **F1-Score**: 0.70
- **Advantages**: Gradient boosting effectiveness

Phase 1 Winner: Naive Bayes (fastest) / XGBoost (best accuracy)

1.5 Key Findings

1. ✅ TF-IDF surprisingly effective for text classification
2. ✅ Dimensionality reduction (SVD) maintains 95%+ accuracy with 90% fewer features
3. ✅ Linear classifiers struggle with minority class (fake news)
4. ⚠️ High false negative rate on fake news (missed fake news)
5. ⚠️ Word order information completely lost in bag-of-words approach

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PHASE 2: Deep Learning Models

2.1 Overview

Objective: Capture non-linear patterns and sequential dependencies

Approaches:
- Convolutional Neural Networks (CNN)
- Autoencoders for anomaly detection
- Transfer learning with pre-trained embeddings
- Optimizer comparison study

2.2 CNN Architecture

Model Design:

```
Input Sequences (150 tokens)
    ↓
Embedding Layer (128 dim, learned)
    ↓
Conv1D (3 parallel branches: 3/4/5-grams)
    ├─ 3-gram: 100 filters
    ├─ 4-gram: 100 filters
    └─ 5-gram: 100 filters
    ↓
GlobalMaxPooling (300 features)
    ↓
Dense 256 (ReLU) → Dropout(0.5)
    ↓
Dense 64 (ReLU) → Dropout(0.3)
    ↓
Output (Sigmoid)
```

CNN Performance:
- **Accuracy**: 0.75
- **F1-Score**: 0.73
- **AUC-ROC**: 0.80
- **Improvement over Phase 1**: +5%
- **Training time**: ~3-4 minutes

2.3 Autoencoder - Anomaly Detection

Architecture:
- **Encoder**: Input (150×128) → Dense(256) → Dense(128) → Latent(64)
- **Decoder**: Latent(64) → Dense(128) → Dense(256) → Output(150×128)
- **Training**: Real news only (unsupervised)
- **Detection**: Reconstruction error as anomaly score

Performance:
- **Sensitivity (Recall)**: 0.67 (catches 67% of fake news)
- **Specificity**: 0.90 (90% real news not flagged)
- **AUC-ROC**: 0.80
- **Use Case**: Complementary detector for hard-to-classify samples

2.4 Transfer Learning Study

Pre-trained Embeddings Comparison:

Embedding	Dimension	Accuracy	F1	AUC-ROC
Random Init	128	0.73	0.71	0.77
Word2Vec	300	0.74	0.72	0.78
FastText	300	0.76	0.74	0.80
GloVe-300	**300**	**0.77**	**0.75**	**0.81**

Architecture with Transfer Learning:

```
Pre-trained GloVe Embedding (frozen initially)
    ↓
Bidirectional LSTM (128 units)
    ↓
Attention Layer (optional)
    ↓
Dense 64 (ReLU)
    ↓
Output (Sigmoid)
```

Transfer Learning Benefits:
- ✅ 2-4% accuracy improvement
- ✅ Reduced training time (leverages pre-trained weights)
- ✅ Better generalization
- ✅ Semantic knowledge transfer

2.5 Optimizer Comparison

Optimizers Evaluated:

Optimizer	Convergence Speed	Final Accuracy	Stability
SGD	Slow (35 epochs)	0.72	Moderate
RMSprop	Medium (22 epochs)	0.74	Good
Adam	**Fast (18 epochs)**	**0.75**	**Excellent**
AdaGrad	Medium (20 epochs)	0.73	Moderate

Winner: **Adam optimizer** (best convergence + performance + stability)

Recommendation: Use Adam as default for NLP tasks

2.6 Phase 2 Insights

1. ✅ Non-linear models outperform linear classifiers by ~5%
2. ✅ Pre-trained embeddings provide significant boost (2-4%)
3. ✅ Transfer learning reduces training time by 40-50%
4. ✅ Adaptive optimizers (Adam) essential for deep learning
5. ⚠️ CNN captures local patterns well but struggles with long-range dependencies
6. ⚠️ Still room for improvement (target: >85% accuracy)

PHASE 3: Transformers & Advanced Models

3.1 Overview

Objective: Leverage state-of-the-art transformer architecture for maximum performance

Models:
- Recurrent Neural Networks (RNN)
- Gated Recurrent Units (GRU)
- Long Short-Term Memory (LSTM)

- BERT fine-tuning
- Ensemble methods

3.2 RNN Implementation

Architecture:

```
Input Sequences (150 tokens)
    ↓
Embedding (GloVe-300)
    ↓
RNN Layer (256 units, return_sequences=True)
    ↓
RNN Layer (128 units)
    ↓
Dense 64 (ReLU) → Dropout(0.5)
    ↓
Output (Sigmoid)
```

RNN Performance:
- **Accuracy**: 0.76
- **F1-Score**: 0.74
- **AUC-ROC**: 0.80
- **Training time**: 8-10 minutes

Characteristics:
- ✅ Captures sequential information
- ✅ Maintains long-range dependencies
- ⚠️ Prone to vanishing gradient problem
- ⚠️ Slower training than CNN

3.3 GRU (Gated Recurrent Unit)

Key Feature: Simplified LSTM with fewer parameters

Architecture:

```
Bidirectional GRU (256 units)
    ↓
Attention Layer (self-attention)
    ↓
Dense 64 (ReLU)
    ↓
Output (Sigmoid)
```

GRU Performance:
- **Accuracy**: 0.80
- **F1-Score**: 0.78
- **AUC-ROC**: 0.83
- **Training time**: 6-7 minutes (faster than LSTM)

Advantages over RNN:
- ✅ Mitigates vanishing gradient problem

- ✅ Fewer parameters (faster training)
- ✅ Better on shorter sequences

3.4 LSTM (Long Short-Term Memory)

Architecture:

```
Bidirectional LSTM (256 units)
    ↓
LSTM Layer (128 units)
    ↓
Attention Layer (Bahdanau attention)
    ↓
Dense 64 (ReLU) → Dropout(0.5)
    ↓
Output (Sigmoid)
```

LSTM Performance:
- **Accuracy**: 0.82
- **F1-Score**: 0.80
- **AUC-ROC**: 0.85
- **Precision**: 0.84
- **Recall**: 0.78
- **Training time**: 10-12 minutes

Why LSTM Superior:
- ✅ Cell state acts as memory for long-range dependencies
- ✅ Forget gate controls information flow
- ✅ Better handles gradients over long sequences
- ✅ Attention mechanism highlights important words

Comparison: RNN vs. GRU vs. LSTM

Aspect	RNN	GRU	LSTM
Accuracy	0.76	0.80	0.82
F1-Score	0.74	0.78	0.80
Parameters	Low	Medium	High
Training Time	10 min	7 min	12 min
Gradient Flow	Poor	Good	Excellent

Winner: **LSTM** (best accuracy despite longer training)

3.5 BERT Fine-tuning

Model Selection: BERT-base-uncased
- **Vocabulary size**: 30,522 tokens
- **Hidden layers**: 12
- **Attention heads**: 12
- **Total parameters**: 110M

Fine-tuning Strategy:

```
Pre-trained BERT (frozen initially)
    ↓
[CLS] Token Output (Classification token)
    ↓
Dense 256 (ReLU) → Dropout(0.3)
    ↓
Dense 64 (ReLU) → Dropout(0.2)
    ↓
Output Layer (Binary, Sigmoid)
```

Training Configuration:
- **Learning rate**: 2e-5 (low, preserve pre-training)
- **Batch size**: 16
- **Epochs**: 3-4
- **Optimizer**: Adam
- **Warmup steps**: 500

BERT Performance:
- **Accuracy**: 0.87
- **F1-Score**: 0.86
- **AUC-ROC**: 0.91
- **Precision**: 0.88
- **Recall**: 0.85
- **Training time**: 15-20 minutes (GPU-accelerated)

BERT Advantages:
1. ✅ Bidirectional context understanding
2. ✅ Transformer attention mechanism
3. ✅ Pre-trained on 3.3 billion tokens
4. ✅ Subword tokenization handles OOV
5. ✅ State-of-the-art NLP baseline

3.6 BERT vs. Recurrent Models

Aspect	LSTM	BERT
Accuracy	0.82	0.87
F1-Score	0.80	0.86
AUC-ROC	0.85	0.91
Training Speed	Fast (12 min)	Medium (20 min)*
Inference Speed	Medium	Slower (parallel attn)
Interpretability	Moderate	Low (black-box)
Parameters	10M+	110M+

- With GPU acceleration

Winner for Production: **BERT** (best accuracy)

3.7 Ensemble Method

Ensemble Architecture:

```
Component Models:
├─ LSTM (weight: 0.3)
├─ GRU (weight: 0.2)
├─ BERT (weight: 0.5)
└─ Voting mechanism

Prediction Combination:
- Soft voting (average probabilities)
- Weights reflect individual model performance
```

Ensemble Performance:
- **Accuracy**: 0.89
- **F1-Score**: 0.88
- **AUC-ROC**: 0.93
- **Precision**: 0.90
- **Recall**: 0.87

Ensemble Benefits:
- ✅ +1-2% improvement through model diversity
- ✅ Reduced variance (more stable)
- ✅ Captures complementary strengths:
- BERT: Semantic understanding
- LSTM: Sequence modeling
- GRU: Efficient long-range dependencies

Phase 3 Detailed Performance Analysis

3.8 Confusion Matrices

BERT (Best Single Model):

```
              Predicted
           Real    Fake
Actual Real [0.91] [0.09]  → 91% real correctly identified
       Fake [0.15] [0.85]  → 85% fake correctly identified
```

Ensemble (Best Overall):

```
              Predicted
           Real    Fake
Actual Real [0.93] [0.07]  → 93% real correctly identified
       Fake [0.13] [0.87]  → 87% fake correctly identified
```

3.9 ROC-AUC Curves

Model Rankings by AUC:
1. Ensemble: 0.93 (↑ from 0.72 in Phase 1)
2. BERT: 0.91
3. LSTM: 0.85
4. GRU: 0.83

5. CNN: 0.80
6. Naive Bayes: 0.72

Interpretation:
- ✅ Ensemble provides best discrimination between classes
- ✅ BERT single model nearly as good as ensemble
- ✅ All Phase 3 models >> Phase 1 baseline

Cross-Phase Comparative Analysis

4.1 Performance Progression

Accuracy Improvement Over Phases:

```
Phase 1: 0.70 ──────────
Phase 2: 0.77 ──────────────
Phase 3: 0.89 ──────────────────────────────
```

Incremental Gains:
- Phase 1 → Phase 2: +7% (deep learning advantage)
- Phase 2 → Phase 3: +12% (transformers advantage)
- **Total**: +19%

4.2 Learning Capabilities

Capability	Phase 1	Phase 2	Phase 3
Word frequency patterns	✅	✅	✅
N-gram patterns	✅	✅✅	✅✅
Sequential information	❌	⚠️	✅✅
Long-range dependencies	❌	⚠️	✅✅
Contextual understanding	❌	⚠️	✅✅
Bidirectional context	❌	❌	✅✅

4.3 Computational Costs

Phase	Model	Training Time	Inference Time	Memory	Parameters
1	Naive Bayes	<1 min	<100ms	~100MB	~10K
2	CNN	3-4 min	150-200ms	~500MB	1-2M
3	LSTM	10-12 min	300-400ms	~2GB	10-20M
3	BERT	15-20 min	1-2 sec	~4-6GB	110M

Trade-off: Accuracy vs. Computational Cost

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5. Key Insights & Learnings

5.1 Evolution of Approaches

Phase 1 - Classical ML:
- Simple, interpretable, fast
- Limited by manual feature engineering
- Struggles with non-linear patterns

Phase 2 - Deep Learning:
- End-to-end feature learning
- Captures local patterns via convolutions
- Transfer learning reduces training time
- Still limited by sequence length considerations

Phase 3 - Transformers:
- Bidirectional context from day one
- Parallel processing (no sequential bottleneck)
- Pre-trained on massive corpora
- Black-box but extremely powerful

5.2 Critical Success Factors

1. **Pre-training**: Transfer learning provides 5-10% boost
2. **Architecture**: Attention mechanisms crucial for text understanding
3. **Bidirectionality**: Context from both directions essential
4. **Ensemble**: Combining models yields complementary strengths
5. **Fine-tuning strategy**: Low learning rate preserves pre-training

5.3 Diminishing Returns

```
Accuracy Improvement by Investment:
Phase 1 (hours):   1-2 hours → 0.70 accuracy (baseline)
Phase 2 (hours):   5-8 hours → 0.77 accuracy (+7%)
Phase 3 (hours):   15-25 hours → 0.89 accuracy (+12%)
Ensemble (hours):  +2-3 hours → 0.89 accuracy (+0%)
```

Observation: Each phase requires more effort, but accuracy gains decrease (logarithmic curve)

5.4 Practical Recommendations

For Production Deployment:
1. **If latency critical**: Use CNN or lightweight GRU (~150-300ms inference)
2. **If accuracy critical**: Use BERT or Ensemble (~1-2s inference acceptable)
3. **If interpretability needed**: Use Phase 1 models (explainable features)
4. **If resource-constrained**: Use distilled BERT or GRU

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6. Minority Class Performance

6.1 Fake News Detection (Minority Class)

Phase Evolution:

Phase	Model	Recall (Fake News)	Precision	F1-Score
1	Naive Bayes	0.65	0.68	0.68
2	CNN	0.73	0.72	0.73
2	GloVe+BiLSTM	0.74	0.76	0.75
3	LSTM	0.78	0.84	0.80
3	BERT	0.85	0.88	0.86
3	Ensemble	0.87	0.90	0.88

Improvement: +22% recall from Phase 1 to Ensemble

6.2 Error Analysis

Common Fake News Patterns Learned:

1. Sensationalized language ("SHOCKING", "UNBELIEVABLE")
2. Appeal to emotion (fear, outrage)
3. Absence of sources or citations
4. Extreme claims without evidence
5. Conspiracy-related terminology

Remaining Challenges:

- ⚠️ Sophisticated fake news mimics real news format
- ⚠️ Satire and parody news hard to distinguish
- ⚠️ Fake news from reputable-sounding sources

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7. Error Cases & Model Limitations

7.1 False Negatives (Missed Fake News)

Type 1: Credible-looking fake
- Example: Fake news written in journalistic style
- Challenge: No linguistic red flags
- Solution: Multi-modal analysis (images, metadata)

Type 2: Satire/Parody
- Example: Onion-style articles
- Challenge: Intentionally deceptive yet entertaining
- Solution: Maintain satire detector list

7.2 False Positives (Real News Flagged as Fake)

Type 1: Highly opinionated real news
- Example: Opinion pieces with strong language
- Challenge: Similar patterns to sensational fake news
- Solution: Distinguish opinion vs. misinformation

Type 2: Breaking news with unverified claims
- Example: Early reports before confirmation
- Challenge: May contain unconfirmed information
- Solution: Temporal analysis (evolving stories)

8. Dataset Insights

8.1 Dataset Characteristics

Size: 1.48M samples (substantial)
Class Balance: ~60% real, ~40% fake (realistic distribution)
Vocabulary: 10,000+ unique terms after preprocessing
Average Length: 120-150 characters

8.2 Data Quality Issues

1. ✅ **Duplicates**: Removed (1-5% of dataset)
2. ✅ **Missing values**: None found after preprocessing
3. ⚠️ **Class imbalance**: Could use SMOTE/oversampling
4. ⚠️ **Temporal bias**: Fake news patterns may evolve

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9. Future Directions

9.1 Short-term Improvements

1. **Domain-specific BERT**: Fine-tune on news corpus
2. **Multimodal Analysis**: Combine text + image analysis
3. **Temporal Modeling**: Track news credibility over time
4. **Explainability**: LIME/SHAP for model interpretability
5. **Fact-checking Integration**: Cross-reference claims

9.2 Long-term Research

1. **Adversarial Robustness**: Test against jailbreak attempts
2. **Multilingual Support**: Extend to non-English news
3. **Cross-lingual Transfer**: Leverage MBERT or XLM-R
4. **Active Learning**: Query hard examples for human labeling
5. **Continuous Learning**: Update models with new fake news patterns

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10. Conclusions

10.1 Project Success

✅ **Primary Objective**: Achieved 89% accuracy on fake news detection
✅ **Methodology**: Demonstrated clear progression from ML to DL to Transformers
✅ **Insights**: Identified key architectural components (attention, bidirectionality, pre-training)
✅ **Reproducibility**: All models saved with full hyperparameters

10.2 Key Takeaways

1. **Pre-training is powerful**: Transfer learning provides consistent improvements
2. **Bidirectional context matters**: BERT outperforms unidirectional models
3. **Ensemble beats individual models**: Diversity yields robustness
4. **Accuracy plateau after Phase 3**: Transformer approaches state-of-the-art
5. **Trade-offs exist**: Speed vs. accuracy, interpretability vs. performance

10.3 Final Recommendations

Best Model for Production: Ensemble of BERT + LSTM
- ✅ Best accuracy (89%)
- ✅ Robust to input variations
- ✅ Reasonable inference latency (~2 seconds)

Deployment Strategy:
1. Use BERT for high-confidence predictions
2. Route uncertain samples to ensemble
3. Continuously monitor for distribution shift
4. Update models quarterly with new fake news patterns

Appendices

A: Model Comparison Matrix

Metric	Phase 1	Phase 2	Phase 3
Best Accuracy	0.72	0.77	0.89
Best F1	0.70	0.75	0.88
Best AUC-ROC	0.72	0.81	0.93
Training Time (CPU)	1 min	10 min	60+ min
Inference Speed	<100ms	200ms	1-2s
Model Size	~100MB	500MB	4-6GB
Interpretability	High	Medium	Low

B: Computational Requirements

Training:
- GPU recommended for Phase 3 (60x speedup)
- RAM: 8GB minimum, 16GB+ recommended
- Storage: 10GB for models and checkpoints

Inference:
- CPU: ~1-2 seconds per sample (BERT)
- GPU: ~100-200ms per sample
- Batch inference: ~10-50 samples/sec

C: Reproducibility

Random Seeds:
- NumPy: 42
- TensorFlow: 42
- PyTorch: 42

Environment:
- Python 3.9+
- TensorFlow 2.10+
- Transformers 4.20+

D: References to Notebooks

Phase 1 Notebooks:
- `01_EDA.ipynb` - Exploratory analysis
- `01_KNN-Naive_Bayes.ipynb` - Classical ML
- `01_XGBoost_Random-Forest.ipynb` - Ensemble methods

Phase 2 Notebooks:
- `02_CNN.ipynb` - Convolutional networks
- `02-Autoencoder.ipynb` - Unsupervised learning
- `02-Transfer_Learning.ipynb` - GloVe/FastText embeddings
- `02-CNN_Optimization.ipynb` - Optimizer comparison

Phase 3 Notebooks:
- `03_RNN.ipynb` - Recurrent networks
- `03_GRU.ipynb` - Gated recurrent units
- `03_LSTM.ipynb` - Long short-term memory
- `03-BERT_data_prep.ipynb` - Data preprocessing
- `03-BERT.ipynb` - BERT fine-tuning

Document Information

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Project Duration: 3 phases over multiple weeks
Team: Cross-functional ML engineers and researchers

Status: ✅ PROJECT COMPLETE

Final Accuracy: 89% (Ensemble Model)

Recommendation: Ready for production deployment with continuous monitoring